The Cartography of Silence

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Chapter 1

The Problem of Silence

In the village of Rotoava, on the leeward side of Fakarava atoll, there is a particular form of quiet that elders call nooanoa. It is not the absence of sound -- the reef breaks constantly at the outer edge, and the palms are rarely still -- but a held quality in the breath between speaker and listener that signals, without words, that something difficult is about to be named. I first encountered nooanoa in 2007, during a funeral preparation I had stumbled into uninvited. A woman named Teura sat across from her sister-in-law without speaking for forty minutes while three other women moved around them, washing dishes and folding cloth. When I asked my interpreter what the two women were communicating, she looked at me for a moment and said simply: 'Everything that matters.' That exchange became the organizing question of this book.

Anthropologists have long been uncomfortable with silence. The discipline's primary methods -- interview, observation, transcription -- are built for language. Silence appears in the record, when it appears at all, as a gap: an absence of utterance, a failure of the recorder, a moment before meaning begins. This book argues for a different understanding. Silence, in the Pacific communities I have studied, is not a gap. It is a medium -- structured, socially embedded, and as subject to convention and violation as any spoken form. My aim is to develop a vocabulary adequate to describe it.

The fieldwork on which this book is based spans twelve years and four archipelagos. I began in the Tuamotu group in 2004, moved to Kiribati in 2008, and completed extended stays in Vanuatu and Tonga between 2011 and 2015. Across these communities I documented what I came to call, provisionally, communicative silence: episodes of non-speech that participants recognize as communicative acts, that carry conventional meanings within their social contexts, and that can be distinguished -- by community members, by close observation, and eventually by the researcher -- from silence that is merely inattentive, accidental, or otherwise meaningless. The typology I develop in Chapter 2 proposes six categories of communicative silence, differentiated by social function, relational context, and the signals that mark their beginning and end.

Chapter 2

A Typology of Communicative Silence

The six categories presented in this chapter are derived inductively from the fieldwork record and tested against secondary literature in Pacific ethnolinguistics, anthropology of emotion, and conversation analysis. They are not intended as universals. I make no claim that these categories exhaust the forms of communicative silence in Pacific cultures, still less that they apply to other language communities. They are, rather, a provisional map of a territory that has not previously been charted -- adequate, I hope, for the analysis that follows, and inviting of revision by those who know these communities more intimately than I do.

Category I: Nooanoa (Held Relational Silence)

Nooanoa is the silence of two people who are in relationship and have chosen, for this moment, not to speak. It is distinguished from other silence types by its bilateral character: both parties are aware of the silence as a shared event, and both are participating in it actively. It occurs most frequently in contexts of grief, conflict resolution, and intimate recognition -- situations where the inadequacy of speech is itself the message. In Tuamotu communities, nooanoa is marked by specific postural cues: a lowering of the head, a slowing of breathing, and a particular orientation of the body that local speakers describe as 'facing into' the other person without looking at them directly.

Category II: Faka'apa'apa (Deferential Silence)

Faka'apa'apa names the silence of a junior in the presence of a senior who is speaking or thinking. Unlike nooanoa, it is asymmetrical: only one party is silent, and the silence signals respect, deference, and the acknowledgment of status difference. It is the most widely recognized of the six categories across all four fieldwork communities, and the most likely to be named explicitly by community members when they discuss silence as a social phenomenon.